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Is Online Help on the Way?

ROUZE puts some major sites' customer service e-mail to the test

By Mike Talon



You ordered *Harry Potter and the Goblet of Fire* on Amazon for your, uh, nephew, but are sent *Harry Potter and the Chamber of Secrets* instead. You search for Amazon's customer support e-mail address, pop out a letter and everything's copacetic. Or is it? ROUZE put customer service e-mail to the test with Amazon.com, eBay.com, Uproar.com and Gap.com.

We asked a friend of ours who does 'Net customer service for a living to come up with typical questions and problems for us to test the four different sites. Then we filled out a Web form or sent an e-mail to each site and waited for the real replies, not just automated e-mail responses. We also tracked how much difficulty we had finding the site's support area, and if amenities like phone numbers were clearly displayed. Here are the results:

Amazon.com

We asked how to redeem a gift certificate to this online book/movie/music retailer. It only took three clicks to reach the customer support form, and the help section was clearly labeled, with phone numbers available if we chose not to write.

We got a reply the following day, with complete instructions on how to redeem our certificate. The e-mail looked pre-written, but it was complete and courteous, and included additional information about specialty certificates (like coupons and promotions), and how to redeem those. Rating: A-

eBay.com

We wrote to this auction site about not being able to see new bids in our browser window. There was no evident way to reach technical support; no links or phone numbers appeared available, though we found a small link through the Billing section that let us ask a technical question.

The next day, we got a pre-written response that really didn't answer our question, but thanked us for bearing with them through technical difficulties. Our question, however, had been designed to sound like the problem was with our browser, not their system. Rating: C-

Uproar.com

This online game site offers prizes for members. We sent an e-mail about not being able to complete the membership registration form due to the browser not going on to the next page after we gave them

our information. Hidden under "Member Services," the support area was difficult to find.

Trying to fill out the tech support form was even more difficult, as we were repeatedly asked for a user name. Unable to register, we didn't have one.

Two days later, no response—automatic or otherwise. We're sure Uproar is busy, but we can't find any excuse for no reply at all. Rating: B

Gap.com

On the Gap home page, we asked how to return a pair of pants we weren't satisfied with. It took only two clicks to find the support area, as well as a phone number to call if we didn't want to fill out the form. Within minutes, we got an e-mail response with a complete answer on how to return our item. It looked like a pre-written form that had been modified with our specific issue in mind.

The Gap's response was quick, accurate and courteous. Rating: A

As in the brick-and-mortar world, it seems as though customer service on the Web is important to some businesses, and not important to others. Hopefully, those getting low marks will listen to their customers' plea for help, before those customers take their business elsewhere.

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